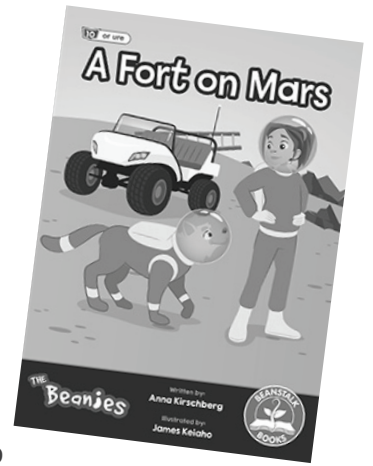




A Fort on Mars

By Anna Kirschberg

Illustrated by James Keiaho



Book Summary

This title looks at a space-themed story about the characters Pip and her dog Kip who are planning to farm on Mars. They set out to build a fort on Mars. In the book, the reader is introduced to new phonics sounds. Detailed and vibrant illustrations depict and help the text explain some basic story information about each page.

This book follows the Beanstalk Books (Letters & Sounds) Phase 3 progression and focuses on learning the next 25 graphemes that are taught in this sequence.

Skills and Strategies

This book builds on decodable reading strategies for high/low readers. The book has been written using a strictly controlled vocabulary. Text uses only **decodable regular words** (according to the week by week progression of Letters & Sounds) along with **'tricky words'** or **'Common Exception Words'** (CEWs). Common Exception Words are frequently used words that are not decodable at this phase.

Phase 3 - Phonics

j	v	w	x	y	z	zz	qu	ch
sh	th	ng	ai	ee	igh	oa	oi	oo
ow	ar	air	ear	er	ur	or	ure	

Tricky Words:

to, the, is, pulls, of, puts, begin, she, are, you, sure, there, all

This book also supports other key reading strategies:

- Recognising the relationship between words and illustrations;
- Pointing one-to-one at each word to ensure an appropriate match;
- Vocabulary and word study.

This book also supports key comprehension strategies:

- Predicting the meanings of new or unfamiliar words from the context of the story;
- Recognising the relationship between letters and their sounds;
- Summarising the main ideas of the story.

Introducing the Text

Open up the discussion about the front cover illustration and make connections with the children's prior knowledge. Prompt discussions by using the vocabulary in the book.

What does the title of the story tell you about the front cover image?

Describe the characters and imagery on the front cover. Where is the setting?

Read the title and the name of the author to the group. Read aloud any common exception words from the front inner cover.

Reading the Text

Pages 2 and 3 – Explain where to begin reading, and ask the student to point to each word as you read aloud together. Pip parks her jeep and Kip runs off to find a good spot to build the fort. Sound out the letter sounds as you go, for example: the 'or' in 'fort'.

Pages 4 and 5 – On these pages, Pip gets the ladder off the jeep and Kip gets the bucket.

Pages 6 and 7 – In the buckets, there are tin, wood and logs. Kip finds some cork and moss under a rock and thinks this will be good for making the fort. Here, the reader will encounter the new r-controlled grapheme 'or' in words like 'cork'. Sound out the letter sounds as you go.

Page 8 – The illustration on the final page shows the characters looking at the fort that they have built. Which words feature the new r-controlled grapheme 'or' in this book?

Students can now read the book independently. At the end of the story, go over the text and illustrations again and discuss what is happening on each page.

Revisiting the Text

As a group, refer back to the table in the front inner cover and identify the words in the story that use the new graphemes being taught in Phase 3.

To start with, identify as many new r-controlled graphemes as you can in the words in the text. For example, 'or' in words like: fort, cork, born.

Look at the use of punctuation in the story. Can you find the pages with a question mark or exclamation mark in the text? Are there any speech marks in this text?

Following Up

Use the BLM for this story, the students can learn more about the introduction of different types of letter sounds (phonics) being used in the text of the story.